speak of daily things: the weather, current work, piled up tasks, travel plans, the constant load-shedding.... Occasionally, there are small complaints—for example, about Victor Banerjee's inadequate spoken Bangla, and later, the unaffordable amount he asks to act in one of Ray's last movies—and then there are the questions of an anxious quasi-parent, about Nilanjana's impending marriage, her putting on weight and so on.

Poet Sampurna Chattarjee's clean and deft English translations are presented alongside the originals, conveying Ray's eloquent but unadorned language. Posited against the other material, the letters show a man who was obsessed by his work and yet had the energy and warmth to communicate with a younger person just for the pleasure of it.

Except for the curving dark walls, this quaint exhibition design could have been from any time between the '60s and '90s. What is on offer is sumptuous, but there seems to be no good reason for the tiny cards with photo-credits pasted at the ideal reading height for a seven-year-old. ■

–Ruchir Joshi



AVIJATRIK (2021)

For many, Ray's Apu trilogy was the last word in cinema, but director Subhrajit Mitra became obsessed with the last words of *Aparajito* that Ray had not adapted. *Avijatrik* finished what Ray had started.

OTT

Against the Stream

Bengali OTT entertainment has taken off, but it sadly remains a prisoner of its own predictability





NEWEST FARE (From top), Mandaar, Srikanto and (bottom) Eken Babu

It was Leo Tolstoy who had famously said, "All great literature is one of two stories; a man goes on a journey or a stranger comes to town." The Russian master seems to have described perfectly modern Bengali entertainment—films and shows that stream on OTT platforms such as Hoichoi, Klikk and Addatimes. There is one problem, however: Not all that streams is "great".

When Anirban Bhattacharya's directorial debut *Mandaar* released on Hoichoi last November, it was rightly lauded as "pathbreaking" and "stunning". Set in a coastal town in Bengal, there was something compelling about his take on *Macbeth*. Though it followed the usual web show recipe—sex, violence, cuss words—its fish-eat-fish world also exceeded these tropes. The same, sadly, cannot be said for other Bengali OTT thrillers.

The average streaming potboiler follows a paint-by-numbers pattern—an idyllic hill station, a murder mystery, two cops, a love story or illicit relationship (for sex and sleaze), then a cliff-hanger. Sohini Sarkar, who has starred in *Mandaar*, *Srikanto* (2022–), *Break Up Story* (2020–), believes such treatment is unfair to the story and viewers: "I say this knowing I'm part of the problem, but I think the trouble lies in how our generation consumes cinema. We can't make a film the way we cook instant noodles, with no thought or research."



Though many of these new shows are made with low budgets, Sarkar says their look and feel have come to matter greatly. "Every other day, I get an offer for another film where they can't tell me much about the character's inner life, but they can tell me about her look, right down to what colour petticoat she wears under her sari." For audiences, this premium on aesthetics serves as a hook of sorts. Thrillers set in hill stations must have brought a lot of views. Because even after *Danny Detective Inc* (2021–), *Murder in the Hills* (2021–) *Sin* (2020–) *Eken Babu* (2018–) and the countless Byomkesh and Feluda remakes, this trope is never-ending.

Bangladesh, in comparison, seems to have taken a grittier path. *Taqdeer* (2020–), *Mohanagar* (2021–) and *Boli* (2021–) are available as "stories beyond borders" on Hoichoi, while the equally refreshing *Ladies and Gentlemen* (2021-) can be streamed on Zee5. This year, SVF, Hoichoi's parent company, plans to "deliver at least 60 new Originals, out of which 20 will be from Bangladesh", says Vishnu Mohta, co-founder, Hoichoi. There is one question, though: How original is "Original"? OTT films and shows often adapt the works of authors from long past, like Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay, Bibhutibhushan Bandyopadhyay and Rabindranath Tagore. "We don't mind watching remake after remake of Batman and Spiderman, so why not these authors and films?" asks actor Parno Mittra. ■

–Malini Banerjee